

PEOPLE'S
MAN: Kalam



First Citizen Singular

In this eulogy by Kalam's secretary, the ex-President comes across as a compassionate man unaffected by the grandeur of his surroundings



THE KALAM EFFECT: MY YEARS WITH THE PRESIDENT
by P.M. NAIR
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 250; Pages: 148

■ By Raj Chengappa

When Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam was sworn in as the eleventh President of India in 2002, few expected the Bharat Ratna awardee and distinguished defence scientist to become one of India's most popular heads of state. The "people's President" would be remembered most for bringing to the ceremonial post a rare blend of dignity, informality, accessibility, erudition and charm. Even as we eagerly await the memoirs of Kalam, who is a prolific writer, P.M. Nair, his self-effacing secretary, has penned what can only be called a eulogy of his five years as Kalam's chief of staff. Nair keeps his narration simple, offering rare glimpses of how Kalam functioned.

His hero comes across as a compassionate, humane individual unaffected by the grandeur of his surroundings and with an eye for detail that included even recording the blossoming of a flower in the Mughal Gardens. Kalam, with his disarming warmth, simplicity and candour, does

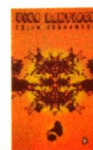
have that effect on most people. Recently, when I rang him up, his first question was: "Are you still a good guy?" Surprised, I could only mumble, "I hope you still think so."

At times Nair bestows Kalam with even a touch of divinity, describing how the weather gods seemed to favour his numerous Presidential tours across the country by bestowing sunshine or clearing storm clouds. Nair does talk about some of the controversial decisions made by Kalam during his term as President including why he recommended the dissolution of the Bihar Assembly in 2005, why he delayed clearing the Office of Profit Bill and how he dealt with Afzal Guru's plea for clemency. While presenting Kalam's point of view on such issues, Nair only goes into as much detail as he feels comfortable with. He reveals how Kalam had decided to resign after the Supreme Court had ruled that the dissolution of the Bihar Assembly was unconstitutional and how he changed his mind after a few days.

One wishes that Nair had explored these key issues—which in many ways defined Kalam's Presidency—at length. Nair's book, then, is just an appetiser before the main course that one expects Kalam's Presidential reminiscences will be. ■

Seaside Secret

A cryptic treasure hunt set in Goa to the beat of Bob Dylan's verse



VIVA SANTIAGO
by COLIN FERNANDES
Penguin
Price: Rs 199
Pages: 137

■ By Bunny Suraiya

I don't know why Colin Fernandes opens with a stale piece of Internet whimsy that's been doing the rounds since 2006. It goes: "Life is not a journey to the grave with the intention of arriving safely in a pretty and well-preserved body, but rather to skid in broadside, thoroughly used up, cocktail in hand and loudly proclaiming—woo-hoo, what a ride!"

Fernandes paraphrases it slightly and attributes it to the eponymous Santiago, the hard-drinking, acid-tripping, hell-raising maternal grandfather of young Alonso Gonzalez who, along with Santiago himself, is one of the two heroes of this novel. The story, obviously inspired by *The Da Vinci Code*, traces a hunt for treasure salvaged by Santiago from Portuguese ships sunk off the coast of Goa, which he hides from his family for no discernible reason. The clues are found on bits of paper strewn around Goa, each leading to the next. They are all verses by Bob Dylan, which require some pretty ingenious interpretation. Obviously, Fernandes is fond of this type of decryption game of looking for hidden meanings in enigmatic pronouncements; there is an interesting discourse on some of Nostradamus's predictions tied somewhat puzzlingly into a theory regarding the presence of the Magi at Christ's nativity.

Affectionately-written vignettes of life on the island of Divar in the river Mandovi, with its tiny population, neighbourliness, feast-days and fishing outings make for enjoyable reading, though it's a pity Fernandes reinforces the stereotype of Goans as alcoholics. The large chunk of the book devoted to unsavoury undergraduate life in Delhi doesn't fit anywhere, however, and should have been left out. ■